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DEMOGRAPHIC AND SETTLEMENT HISTORY OF CIRCASSIA AND CENTRAL CISCAUCASIA.

A Regional Literature Review of Population and Settlement (10000BC - 1900AD).

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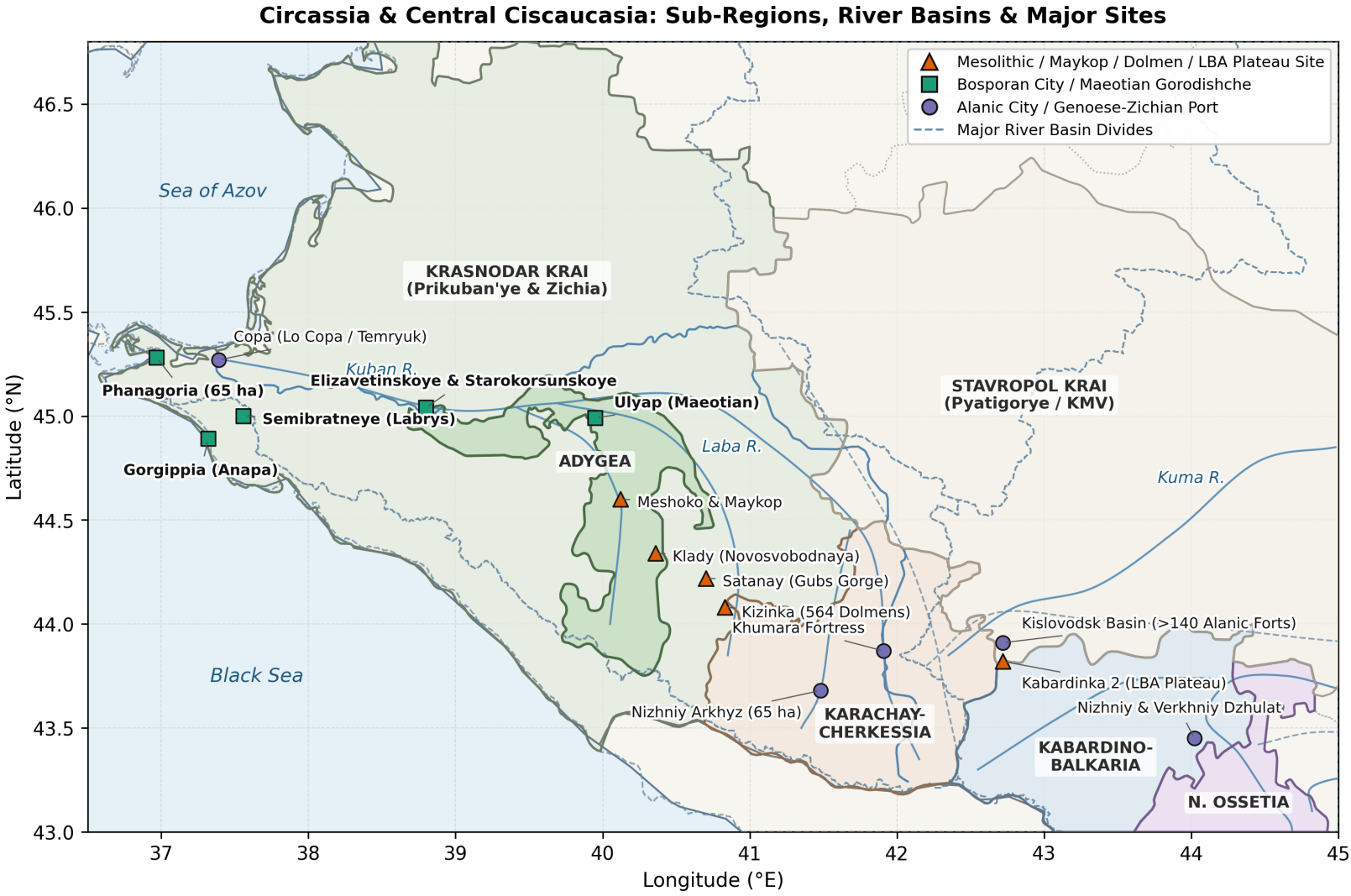


Figure 1. Sub-regions, river basins, and principal archaeological and historical settlements of Circassia and Central Ciscaucasia (10000BC - 1900AD).

Abstract

This paper reviews the archaeological, geoarchaeological, bioarchaeological, classical-epigraphic, and archival literature to reconstruct the population and settlement history of Historical Circassia and Central Ciscaucasia (122,9k km^2 across Krasnodar Krai, Adygea, Karachay-Cherkessia, Kabardino-Balkaria, North Ossetia-Alania, and the Pyatigorye / Kislovodsk basin of southern Stavropol Krai) from 10000BC to 1900AD. Avoiding raw site-count extrapolations, our synthesis traces long-term demographic change across six major historical periods: (1) Terminal Pleistocene and Early Holocene rock-shelter foragers at Satanay (Gubs Gorge) and Sosruko (Baksan Gorge) (2,0k in 10000BC -> 13,0k in 5000BC) [1][2][3]; (2) Eneolithic fortified stone villages (Meshoko, Yasenova Polyana, Svobodnoe) and the Early and Middle Bronze Age Maykop-Novosvobodnaya, Western Caucasian Dolmen (>2 300-3 000 megaliths), and North Caucasian cultures (70,0k in 3000BC -> 100,0k in 2000BC) [4][5][6][7]; (3) the Late Bronze Age high-mountain plateau settlement (>260 symmetrical stone villages at 1 400-2 400 m around Mount Elbrus) and the Western and Central Koban agricultural terrace expansion (160,0k in 1500BC -> 225,0k in 1000BC) [8][9][10]; (4) the Classical Asiatic Bosporus cities (Phanagoria, Gorgippia, Hermonassa, Semibratneye) and the >200 Maeotian fortified towns (*gorodishcha*) of the Kuban plain (310,0k in 500BC -> 340,0k at 1AD) [11][12][13]; (5) the Early and High Medieval Western Alanic (Nizhniy Arkhyz, Khumara, Kislovodsk Basin [>140 forts], Verkhniy and Nizhniy Dzhulat) and Zichian-Kasogian peak (470,0k around 1200AD) [9][14][15][16], followed by the 1238-1395 Mongol and Timurid invasions (330,0k in 1400AD) and the early modern growth of Western Circassia, Greater and Lesser Kabarda, Abaza, Karachay-Balkaria, Ossetia, and the Lesser Nogai Horde to 600,0k (530,0k-680,0k) by 1700AD [17][18][19][20]; and (6) the 18th-19th-century demographic transformation, in which the Caucasian War (1817-1864) and the 1860-1864 *muhajir* expulsion of 400,0k-500,0k+ Western Circassians (Shapsugs, Natukhais, Abadzekhs, Ubykhs) and Abaza to the Ottoman Empire were followed by large-scale Kuban Cossack and Slavic peasant settlement across Kuban Oblast, Black Sea Governorate, and Western Terek Oblast, lifting total regional population to 2 420,0k (2,42M; range 2,30M-2,55M) by 1900AD [21][22][23][24][25].

Background

Stretching 650 km from the Taman Peninsula and the Kerch Strait (Cimmerian Bosporus) across the chernozem plains of the Kuban (*Prikuban'ye*) and the Sub-Elbrus volcanic plateaus to the Darial Gorge on the upper Terek, Northwestern and Central Ciscaucasia (122,9k km^2) comprises five connected sub-regions (Figure 1 and Table 1).

The first sub-region encompasses the Taman Peninsula, the Black Sea littoral (*Zichia* from Anapa to Sochi), the Azov reed-flats, and the lower and middle Kuban chernozem plains (Krasnodar Krai, 75,5k km^2). This corridor hosted the richest Early Bronze Age royal kurgans (Maykop, Staromyshastovskaya), >200 Classical Maeotian fortified towns (Elizavetinskoye, Starokorsunskoye, Semibratneye), the Greek polis cities of Phanagoria (65 ha) and Gorgippia (40 ha), 39 Genoese-Zichian trading ports (Matrega, Copa, Mapa, Maurocastro), the early modern Western Circassian tribes and principalities (Zhaney, Temirgoy, Bjedukh, Hatukay, Shapsug, Natukhai, Abadzekh, Ubykh), and, after 1792-1864, the administrative heartland of Kuban Oblast (Yekaterinodar) and Black Sea Governorate (Novorossiysk) [11][12][17][19][24].

In the Trans-Kuban foothills and dolmen belt (Republic of Adygea, 7,8k km^2), drained by the Belaya, Laba, Fars, and Pshish rivers, Adygea contains the stratified Eneolithic stone fortresses (Meshoko, Yasenova Polyana), the eponymous Oshad kurgan of Maykop, the Klady (Novosvobodnaya) megalithic tombs, dense clusters of Bronze Age slab and trough dolmens (Kizinka, Deguako, Bogatyrskaya Polyana), the Maeotian sanctuary kurgans of Ulyap, and the core territory of the Temirgoy (*Kemirgoy*) and Hatukay principalities (modern Maykop Otdel) [1][4][6].

Across the upper Kuban, Zelenchuk, and Teberda gorges (Karachay-Cherkessia, 14,3k km^2), controlling the Klukhor and Marukh passes into Abkhazia, this sub-region hosted the 8th-10th century fortress of Khumara (Хумаринское городище, 25 ha), the 10th-12th century metropolitan see of Alania at Nizhniy Arkhyz (Нижне-Архызское городище, 65 ha with three standing Byzantine stone churches), and the early modern territories of the Besleney Circassians, Abaza (Tapanta / Altykesek and Shkaraua), and Karachay (Карачай) in the Batalpashinsk Otdel [14][15][26][27].

In the Kislovodsk basin (*Pyatigorye*) and Sub-Elbrus high plateaus (Kabardino-Balkaria [12,5k km^2] + Pyatigorye / KMV [4,8k km^2] = 17,3k km^2), between the Baksan-Malka-Cherek gorges and the Podkumok-Eshkakon limestone basin around Kislovodsk (800 km^2), systematic surveys by Sabine Reinhold and D. S. Korobov (2004-2020) documented over 260 Late Bronze Age stone plateau settlements (1 400-2 400 m, e.g., Kabardinka 2), 16,1% terraced agricultural land coverage (Koban and Alanic periods), and over 140 Early Medieval Alanic promontory fortresses (5th-8th centuries AD) [8][9][28], succeeded by the Golden Horde city of Nizhniy Dzhulat (Нижний Джулат), the princely federation of Greater and Lesser Kabarda alongside the Five Balkar Mountain Societies, and the 19th-century Nalchik Okrug and Pyatigorsk/Kislovodsk spa towns [17][29][30].

Finally, the upper Terek and Darial corridor (North Ossetia-Alania, 8,0k km^2) is anchored by the eponymous Koban (Кобан) cemetery in the Gizeldon gorge, the Alanic-Golden Horde city of Verkhniy Dzhulat (Верхний Джулат / Tatartup / Dedyakov) at the Elkhotovo Gates, the Zmeyskaya catacomb necropolis, the four post-Timurid Ossetian mountain societies (Digor, Alagir, Kurtat, Tagaur), and the Russian fortress and administrative capital of Vladikavkaz (founded 1784) [31][32].

Methodology

Regional Subdivisions

Sub-Regional Unit	Elevation	Area (km2)	River Basins	Key Archaeological and Historical Centres
Krasnodar Krai (Taman, Black Sea Coast and Kuban Plain)	0 to 3 256 m	75,5k	Lower/Middle Kuban, Taman delta, Eya-Chelbas Azov steppe and Pontic rivers	Phanagoria, Gorgippia, Semibratneye, Elizavetinskoye, Yekaterinodar, Novorossiysk
Republic of Adygea (Belaya-Laba Foothills and Dolmen Belt)	50 to 3 238 m	7,8k	Belaya, Laba, Fars, Kurdzhips and Gubs river valleys	Meshoko, Maykop (Oshad), Klady (Novosvobodnaya), Satanay, Kizinka, Ulyap
Karachay-Cherkessia (Upper Kuban, Zelenchuk and Teberda)	400 to 5 642 m	14,3k	Upper Kuban, Bolshoy and Malyy Zelenchuk, Urup and Teberda	Nizhniy Arkhyz (65 ha), Khumara Fortress (25 ha), Batalpashinsk
Kabardino-Balkaria and Pyatigorye / Kislovodsk Basin	150 to 5 642 m	17,3k	Podkumok-Kuma (Kislovodsk), Malka, Baksan, Chegem and Cherek	Sosruko, Kabardinka 2, Kislovodsk forts (>140), Nizhniy Dzhulat, Nalchik, Pyatigorsk
North Ossetia-Alania (Upper Terek, Ardon and Darial Gorge)	130 to 5 033 m	8,0k	Upper Terek, Urukh, Ardon, Fiagdon, Gizeldon and Kambileyevka	Koban, Zmeyskaya, Verkhniy Dzhulat (Tatartup), Dargavs, Vladikavkaz

(Continued from previous page)

Sub-Regional Unit	Elevation	Area (km2)	River Basins	Key Archaeological and Historical Centres
Total Circassia and Central Ciscaucasia	0 to 5 642 m	122,9k	Azov-Black Sea (Kuban) and Caspian (Kuma-Terek) drainage basins	Over 5 000 mapped prehistoric, classical, and medieval monuments

Table 1. Sub-regional units, river basins, and major archaeological and historical sites of Circassia and Central Ciscaucasia.

Estimation Methods

To estimate regional population across 122,9k km^2 from 10000BC to 1900AD, we combine five quantitative methods.

For the Late Bronze Age high-plateau stone settlements and Koban terraces (1600-500BC), we use Sabine Reinhold's inventory of >260 Late Bronze Age stone plateau villages (1 400-2 400 m; 10-36 double-row stone courtyard houses per village; 80-200 inhabitants per site) [8][33] and D. S. Korobov and A. V. Borisov's land-use study of the Kislovodsk basin (800 km^2, 16,1% terraced surface area capable of supporting 15,0k-25,0k inhabitants in that single basin alone) [9][28][34][35].

For the Asiatic Bosporus polis cities and Maeotian fortified towns (*gorodishcha*) (500BC-300AD), we combine urban walled area (Phanagoria [65 ha], Gorgippia [40 ha], Hermonassa [25 ha], Semibratneye / Labrys [14 ha], Patraeus, Kepoi at 100-130 persons/ha) [12][13][36] with I. I. Marchenko's and N. V. Anfimov's survey of over 200 fortified Maeotian *gorodishcha* and open *selishcha* lining the Kuban terrace bluffs (2-15 ha each, plus the 200-ha Elizavetinskoye delta trading town) [11][37][38][39].

For the Alanic period (400-1238AD), we apply Korobov's (2017) catchment model of >140 Early Medieval Alanic stone fortresses and >700 sites in the Kislovodsk basin (1,5-2,5 km spacing between forts; 12,0k-22,0k basin inhabitants) [9][16][40] alongside the Christian Alanic capital at Nizhniy Arkhyz (65 ha, 6,0k-10,0k inhabitants) [14][41], Khumara (25 ha) [15], Nizhniy Dzhulat, and Verkhniy Dzhulat (Tatartup) [31].

For the early modern period (1500-1800AD), we cross-check Giorgio Interiano (1502), Giovanni da Lucca (1625), Evliya Çelebi (1666-1667), Xavier Glavani (1724), Johann Anton Güldenstädt (1770-1773), and P. S. Pallas (1793) alongside Russian *Posolskiy Prikaz* registers (1552-1700) analysed by V. K. Gardanov [17], E. N. Kusheva [29], S. Kh. Khotko [18][19][30][42][43], and V. V. Trepalov [20].

Finally, 19th-century estimates (1800-1900AD) combine General A. P. Berger's (1860-1882) and T. Kh. Kumykov's (1994) archival records of the 1858-1865 Circassian and Abaza *muhajir* deportations [22][23], V. M. Kabuzan's (1996) ethnostatistical reconstructions of Ciscaucasia (1795-1897) [21], and the 1897 First All-Russian Imperial Census volumes for Kuban Oblast (Vol. 65: 1 918 881 inhabitants), Black Sea Governorate (Vol. 70: 57 478 inhabitants), and the western *okrugs* of Terek Oblast (Vol. 68: Nalchik, Vladikavkaz, Pyatigorsk, and Mozdok) [24][25][44].

Historical Overview

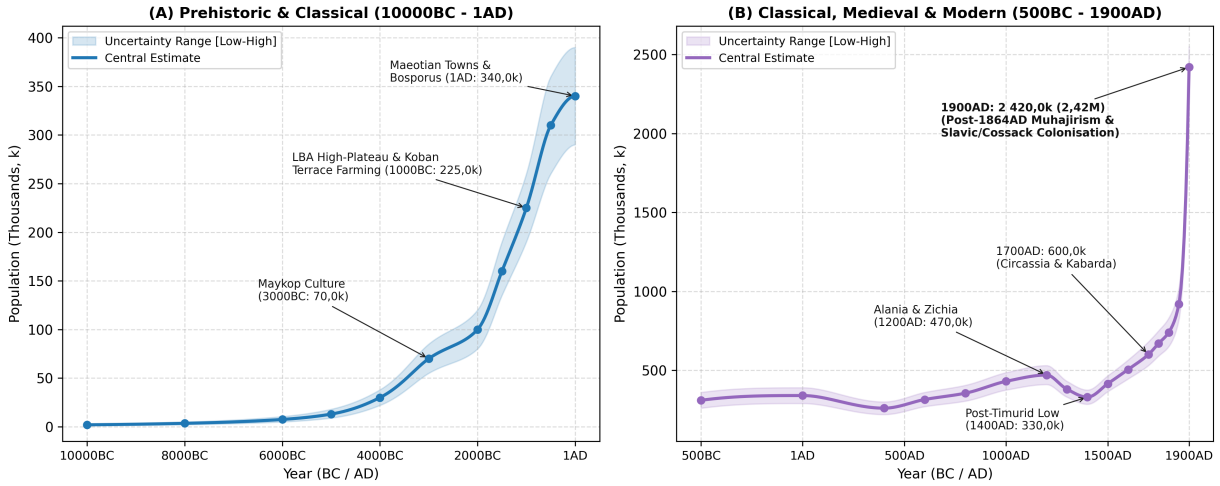


Figure 2. Estimated population of Circassia and Central Ciscaucasia with uncertainty ranges from Mesolithic foragers to the 1897 Imperial Census (10000BC - 1900AD).

Mesolithic, Neolithic, and Eneolithic Villages: Satanay, Sosruko, and Meshoko (10000 - 3700BC)

During the Terminal Pleistocene and Early Holocene (10000-5000BC), hunter-gatherer bands occupied karst rock-shelters across both the northwestern foothills (Satanay / Gubskiy Naves No. 7, Chygai, Dvoinaya, and Kasozhskaya caves in the Gubs gorge of Adygea/Krasnodar) and the central volcanic canyons (Sosruko and Badynoko rock-shelters in the Baksan gorge of Kabardino-Balkaria) [1][2][3][45]. Stratified hearths at Sosruko (Layers 7-4) and Satanay preserve geometric obsidian and flint microliths, bone harpoons, edible land snails (*Helix*), and bones of Caucasian tur, wild boar, and red deer, supporting a gradual regional rise from 2,0k (10000BC) to 7,5k (6000BC) and 13,0k (5000BC).

In the mid-5th millennium BC (Eneolithic, 4500-3700BC), settled farmers established the Meshoko-Svobodnoe (Darkveti-Meshoko) culture in the Belaya and Kuban foothills [1][4][5].

Excavated by A. A. Formozov and A. D. Rezepkin among the fortified promontory villages (Meshoko, Yasenova Polyana, Skala, Myskhako) and steppe settlements (Svobodnoe), Meshoko (Мешоко) occupied a cliff-lined limestone plateau in Adygea protected by a 150-metre-long, 4-metre-thick dry-stone defensive wall, while Svobodnoe on the Kuban plain was enclosed by a circular ditch-and-palisade system (~2,5 ha, 25-40 rectangular wattle-and-daub houses) [1][4][5]. Subsisting on domesticated cattle, pigs (up to 30-40% at Meshoko), and emmer and barley cultivation, and participating in long-distance copper and obsidian exchange (as seen in the Nalchik Eneolithic cemetery of 121 ochre-stained burials in Kabardino-Balkaria), total regional population reached 30,0k (22,0k-38,0k) by 4000BC.

Early and Middle Bronze Ages: The Maykop Culture and Western Caucasian Dolmens (3700 - 1600BC)

Between 3700 and 2900BC, Northwestern and Central Ciscaucasia formed the core of the Maykop-Novosvobodnaya culture (Майкопско-новосвободненская общность), documented in the monographs and radiocarbon chronologies of S. N. Korenevskiy, R. M. Munchaev, and V. A. Trifonov [4][46][47][48][49].

Excavations of open river-terrace Maykop settlements along the Kuban and Terek (Galyugay I-III, Sereginskoye, Chekon, Bolshoy Tegink, with Galyugay I spanning 6-8 ha of large circular sunken-floor wattle-and-daub dwellings of 50-80 m^2) demonstrate that the great royal kurgans - such as the 11-metre-high Maykop (Oshad) kurgan (1897), Kishpek, Marinskaya, and the Klady (Novosvobodnaya) megalithic two-chamber stone tombs - were supported by a wide network of wheel-made pottery-producing farming villages [4][46][47]. Palaeogenetic (aDNA) and craniological studies confirm strong continuity among Caucasian Hunter-Gatherer (CHG) and Anatolian-Iranian Neolithic farming populations alongside steppe exchange [50][51]. By 3000BC, regional population reached 70,0k (55,0k-85,0k).

During the subsequent Western Caucasian Dolmen culture (Дольменная культура Западного Кавказа, 2900-1400BC) across the wooded mountain valleys from the Taman-Anapa coast (Pshekh, Pshada, Dzhubga) to the Belaya and Laba headwaters (Kizinka, Deguako, Bogatyrskaya Polyana), V. I. Markovin and V. A. Trifonov catalogued between 2 300 and 3 000 megalithic stone dolmens (slab, composite, trough-shaped, and monolithic tombs weighing 15-50 tonnes; clustered in cemeteries of up to 564 dolmens at Kizinka and >300 at Bogatyrskaya Polyana) [6][7][52][53][54]. Excavations at the fortified settlement of Deguako-Dakhovskoye and collective chamber burials (15-70 individuals per dolmen) attest to settled mountain-forest communities, which - together with the North Caucasian (*Severokavkazskaya*) and Piedmont Catacomb cultures of Central Ciscaucasia - supported 100,0k (80,0k-120,0k) inhabitants by 2000BC.

Late Bronze and Early Iron Ages: High-Plateau Stone Villages and Koban Terraces (1600 - 400BC)

During the mid-2nd millennium BC (1600-1000BC), Russian-German surveys led by Sabine Reinhold, D. S. Korobov, and A. B. Belinskiy (2004-2017) identified a major Late Bronze Age high-mountain plateau settlement phase (1 400-2 400 m elevation) stretching 140 km across the sub-alpine limestone plateaus north of Mount Elbrus (Kislovodsk / Pyatigorye, Karachay-Cherkessia, and Kabardino-Balkaria) [8][9][55].

Using aerial photography, geomagnetic survey, and excavations at Kabardinka 2, Pravoberezhnaya Berezovaya, and Tambukan, Reinhold et al. (2017) mapped over 260 permanent stone-built villages laid out in symmetrical linear or oval plans around central livestock enclosures (10-36 double-row stone houses per village; 80-200 inhabitants per settlement; 20,0k-35,0k high-plateau inhabitants during 1500-1100BC) (Figure 3A) [8][56].

Following climate cooling around 1000-900BC, communities of the Western and Central Koban culture (1100-400BC) moved 400-600 m down into the mid-mountain valleys (800-1 300 m), establishing classic Koban Culture (Кобанская культура) settlements and cemeteries (Koban, Tli, Verkhnyaya Rutkha, Kumbulta in Ossetia; Bylym, Zayukovo in Kabardino-Balkaria; the Kislovodsk basin; Tereze and Kyzyl-Kala in Karachay-Cherkessia; and Proto-Maeotian sites on the Kuban plain) [9][10]. In the 800 km^2 Kislovodsk basin alone, >130 Koban settlements built agricultural lynchet terraces across 16,1% of the landscape (Figure 3B) [9][28][34], raising total regional population from 160,0k (1500BC) to 225,0k (190,0k-260,0k) by 1000BC.

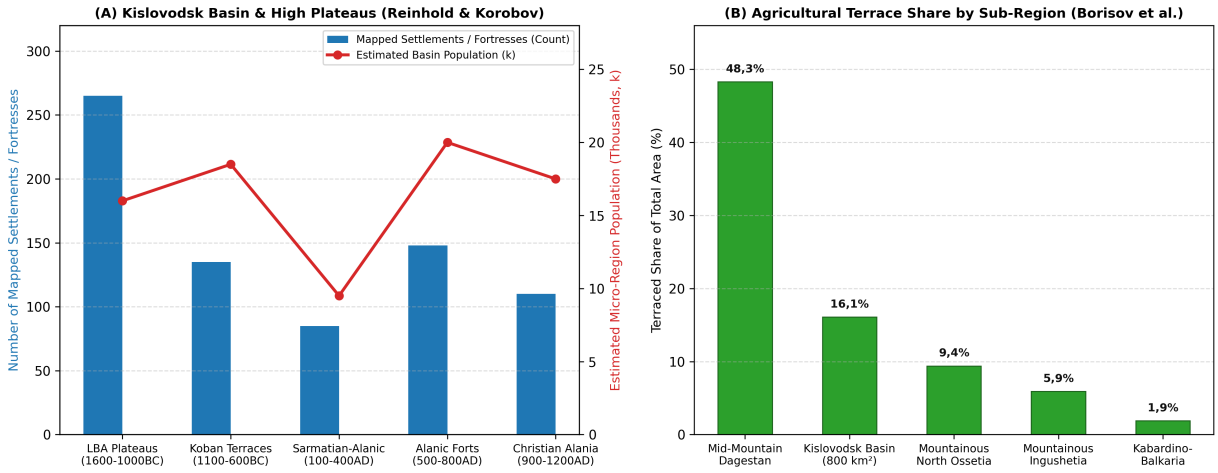


Figure 3. Mapped settlements and population in the Kislovodsk Basin and agricultural terrace coverage across five North Caucasian regions (1600BC - 1200AD).

Classical Antiquity: The Asiatic Bosporus and Maeotian Fortified Towns (500BC - 350AD)

Between the 6th century BC and the 3rd century AD, Northwestern Ciscaucasia supported a dense population through the commercial ties between the Greek cities of the Asiatic Bosporus (Азиатский Боспор) and the settled farming Maeotian (Меоты) tribes of the Kuban basin [11][12][13][36][38][39][57].

In the polis cities and rural territory (*chora*) of the Asiatic Bosporus on the Taman Peninsula and at Anapa, Phanagoria (Фанагория), founded by Teian colonists c. 543BC, became the eastern capital of the Bosporan Kingdom (65 ha walled upper and lower city plus >22 ha submerged in Taman Bay and >600 kurgans; 10,0k-15,0k urban residents) [12][36]. Gorgippia (Горгиппия / Anapa, 40 ha; 6,0k-9,0k residents), Hermonassa (Taman, 25 ha), Kepoi, Patraeus, and the Sindian capital Labrys (Semibratneye gorodishche, 14 ha) were surrounded by >250 rural farmsteads (*chora*) exporting grain and salted fish to Athens and Pontus (55,0k-75,0k total inhabitants in the Asiatic Bosporus) [13][57].

Along the high right-bank terrace of the Kuban from Ust-Labinsk to Krasnodar and across the Laba-Belaya and Ponura-Kirpili rivers, N. V. Anfimov and I. I. Marchenko mapped over 200 fortified Maeotian *gorodishcha* (Elizavetinskoye [200 ha outer enclosure / 12 ha inner citadel], Starokorsunskoye No. 2, Pashkovskoye, Voronezhskoye, Ust-Labinskoye), each surrounded by 3-8 open agricultural villages (*selishcha*) and flat cemeteries containing 500-3 000+ graves [11][37][38][58]. Strabo (*Geography* 11,5.8) recorded that the neighbouring Siraces (Сираки) and Aorsi (Аорсы) of the Kuban-Kuma steppes could field 20 000 and 200 000 horsemen respectively. Combined with the Sarmatian-Koban population of Central Ciscaucasia, total regional population reached 310,0k (500BC) and 340,0k (290,0k-390,0k) at 1AD, before declining to 260,0k in 400AD during the Gothic and Hunnic wars (c. 370-375AD).

Early and High Middle Ages: Western Alania, *Zichia*, and the Mongol and Timurid Invasions (400 - 1450AD)

Between the 5th and early 13th centuries AD, population grew across both the Christian Kingdom of Alania (Алания) in Central Ciscaucasia and the coastal and foothill confederation of Zichia / Kasogia (Зихия / Касогия) in the northwest. As mapped by D. S. Korobov (2012, 2017, 2023) and G. E. Afanasyev, over 140 single-layer stone promontory castles (Rim-Gora, Klin-Yar, Khasaut) and >700 total sites occupied the 800 km^2 Kislovodsk basin during the 5th-8th centuries AD (15,0k-22,0k inhabitants in that single basin)

[9][16][33][35][40].

During the 9th-13th centuries AD, Christian Alanic metropolitan cities anchored the upper Kuban and Terek valleys. Extending 3,5 km along the Bolshoy Zelenchuk valley (1 150 m) behind three stone defensive walls (65 ha intramural area), Nizhniy Arkhyz (Нижне-Архызское городище) served as the seat of the Byzantine Metropolitan of Alania (established 914-916AD under Patriarch Nicholas Mystikos). Excavations by V. A. Kuznetsov documented three standing cross-domed stone cathedrals (North, Middle, and South Zelenchuk churches), 11 smaller chapels, paved stone streets, residential quarters, and >1 000 stone-cist and catacomb burials, supporting 6,0k-10,0k urban inhabitants [14][27][31][41]. Nearby Khumara (Хумаринское городище, upper Kuban, 25 ha) was protected by a 5-7 m thick ashlar stone wall with 19 towers and Turkic runic inscriptions (3,0k-5,0k inhabitants) [15], while Illichevskoye (Ильичевское городище, Otradnaya district, 45 ha with 6 stone churches), Nizhniy Dzhulat (Mayskiy, Kabardino-Balkaria), and Verkhniy Dzhulat (Tatartup / Dedyakov, North Ossetia, >35 ha with Christian churches, two Golden Horde minarets, and a brick mosque) controlled the main piedmont corridors [31][32][59].

In Krasnodar and Adygea (Zichia, Kasogia, and Taman), cremation-and-inhumation kurgan fields (Borisovskiy, Dyurso, Moldavanovskiy, Kazazovo with >800 burials) and the Taman port of Tmutarakan (Matrega) supported a dense Zichian-Kasogian farming population (195,0k in Krasnodar + 28,0k in Adygea by 1200AD), lifting total regional population to 470,0k (410,0k-530,0k) around 1200AD [19][60][61].

While Batu and Möngke devastated central Alania in 1238-1240 (and Mengu-Timur stormed Dedyakov / Verkhniy Dzhulat in 1278), an active urban network persisted under Golden Horde rule at Verkhniy Dzhulat, Nizhniy Dzhulat, and Madzhar (380,0k in 1300AD) until Timur's 1395 campaign burned the Circassian Kuban forests, stormed the Elbrus gorges (*Buriberd*, *Kula*, *Taus*), and destroyed both Dzhulats [31][42][43][62]. Regional population fell to 330,0k (285,0k-375,0k) in 1400AD, while survival of Alanic communities in the Digor, Alagir, Kurtat, Tagaur, and Balkar-Karachay gorges was accompanied by the 15th-century eastward expansion of the Kabardian Circassians across Pyatigorye, Baksan, and the Terek bend [17][42][63].

Early Modern Circassia, Kabarda, Abaza, Karachay-Balkaria, Ossetia, and the Lesser Nogais (1500 - 1700AD)

Between 1450 and 1700AD, the recovery of Black Sea, Crimean, Ottoman, and Russian Terki-Astrakhan trade routes carried total regional population from 415,0k (1500AD) to 505,0k (1600AD) and 600,0k (530,0k-680,0k) by 1700AD (Figure 4 and Table 2).

Drawing on the Italian, Ottoman, French, and Russian accounts analysed by V. K. Gardanov [17], E. N. Kusheva [29], N. G. Volkova [26], S. Kh. Khotko [18][19][64][65][66], and V. V. Trepalov [20], six principal regional groups can be reconstructed. In Western Circassia (Западная Черкесия - Krasnodar Krai and Adygea, 300,0k-350,0k), Giorgio Interiano (1502) noted that the Circassians could muster >20 000 noble heavy cavalry (*uzden* and *pshi*) plus peasant infantry; in 1666-1667, the Ottoman traveller Evliya Çelebi (*Seyahatnâme*, Vol. VII) travelled across the Circassian lands from Taman and Anapa through Shegak, Zhaney, Hatukay, Temirgoy (*Kemirgoy* / Bolotoko), Bjedukh, Abadzekh, and Kabarda, recording 3 000 to 10 000 armed warriors per principality (~70 000-85 000 total fighting men across all Circassian tribes) [17][18]. In 1724, the French consul in Crimea Xavier Glavani (*Description de la Circassie*) compiled a district-by-district household (*maison*) count across 14 Western and Central Circassian provinces (Temirgoy: >5 000 households in 40 large villages; Besleney: 1 500 households; Bjedukh, Hatukay, Zhaney, Shapsug, Natukhai, Abadzekh), confirming 52,0k-62,0k Western Circassian households (300,0k-350,0k inhabitants) [17][18][65].

In Greater and Lesser Kabarda (Большая и Малая Кабарда, 115,0k-145,0k), following the 1557 diplomatic

alliance with Ivan IV (Temryuk Idarovich), Russian *Posolskiy Prikaz* embassies (1589-1700) documented the four princely houses of Greater Kabarda (Kaytukino, Atazhukino / Hatokshoko, Misostovo, Bekmurzino along the Malka, Baksan, Cherek, and Pyatigorye) and Lesser Kabarda (Talostanovo and Dzholyakhstanovo / Mudarovo along the Terek bend), capable of fielding 10 000-15 000 noble cavalry and 20 000 infantry (19,0k-24,0k households across >150 princely and *uzden kabaki*; 115,0k-145,0k inhabitants) [17][29][30][67]. The Lesser Nogai Horde (Малая Ногайская Орда / Kazyev Ulus), founded by Ghazi Mirza in the 1550s across the Kuban-Azov steppes (*Prikuban'ye*) and Pyatigorye, together with Ottoman garrisons at Azov, Temryuk, Taman, and Anapa, comprised 9,0k-11,0k *kibitkas*/households and 50,0k-65,0k inhabitants [20].

In the mountain gorges, the Abaza (Абазины - Tapanta / Altykesek and Shkaraua) inhabited the upper Kuban, Zelenchuk, Urup, and Laba valleys (Bibard, Loov, Dudaruq, Klych, Kech, Tram *kabaki*; 6,5k-8,5k households; 38,0k-47,0k inhabitants) [26][29]. The four Ossetian mountain societies (Tagaur, Kurtat, Alagir, Digor) occupied the fortified stone tower villages (Dargavs, Tsmiti, Nuzal, Zadalesk) of North Ossetia (7,0k-9,0k households; 44,0k-54,0k inhabitants) [26][32], while Karachay and the five Balkar mountain societies (Baksan / Urusbiev, Chegem, Khulam, Bezengi, Balkar / Malkar) comprised 4,0k-5,2k mountain stone homesteads (25,0k-32,0k inhabitants) around Mount Elbrus [26][29].

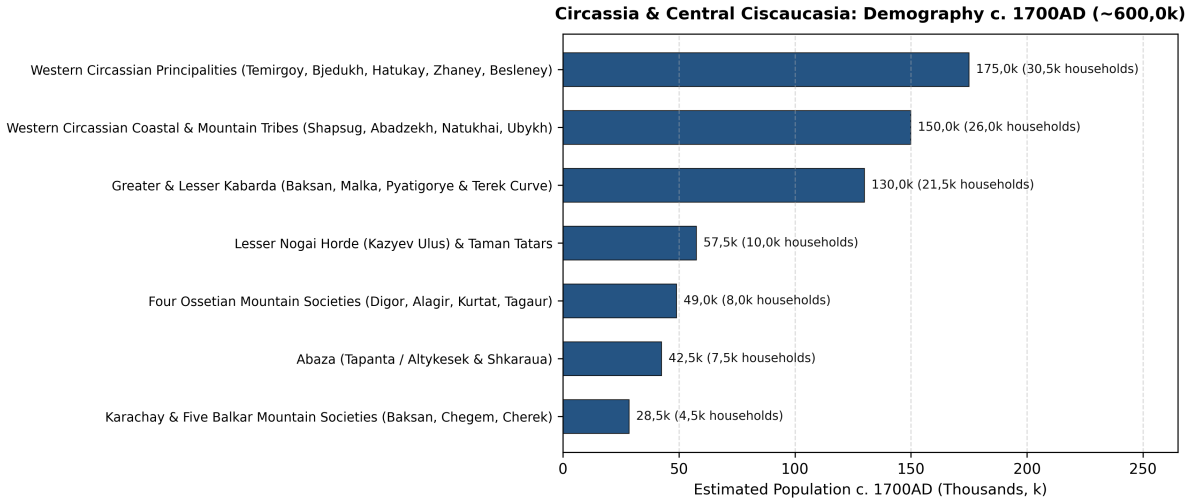


Figure 4. Estimated population and household counts across Circassia and Central Ciscaucasia around 1700AD from Ottoman, French, and Russian registers.

Sub-Ethnic Group / Principality Union	Primary Sub-Region	Households (Dvors/ Kibitkas)	Militia (Cavalry and Foot)	Estimated Population
Western Circassian Principalities (Temirgoy, Bjedukh, Hatukay, Zhaney, Besleney, Mamkhegh)	Krasnodar, Adygea and W. Karachay-Cherkessia	28,0k - 33,0k	25,0k - 32,0k	160,0k - 190,0k
Western Circassian Coastal and Mountain Tribes (Shapsug, Abadzekh, Natukhai, Ubykh)	Black Sea Littoral (Anapa-Sochi) and Western Slopes	24,0k - 28,0k	22,0k - 28,0k	135,0k - 165,0k

(Continued from previous page)

Sub-Ethnic Group / Principality Union	Primary Sub-Region	Households (Dvors/ Kibitkas)	Militia (Cavalry and Foot)	Estimated Population
Greater and Lesser Kabarda (Atazhukino, Kaytukino, Misostovo, Bekmurzino, Talostanovo, Dzholyakhstanovo)	Kabardino-Balkaria, Pyatigorye and Terek Curve	19,0k - 24,0k	20,0k - 28,0k	115,0k - 145,0k
Lesser Nogai Horde (Kazyev Ulus) and Ottoman Taman-Temryuk-Anapa Ports	Azov-Kuban Steppe (Krasnodar) and Taman	9,0k - 11,0k	10,0k - 14,0k	50,0k - 65,0k
Four Ossetian Mountain Societies (Digor, Alagir, Kurtat, Tagaur)	North Ossetia-Alania (Upper Terek and Ardon)	7,0k - 9,0k	7,0k - 9,5k	44,0k - 54,0k
Abaza (Tapanta / Altykesek Six-Clan Federation and Shkaraua Mountain Clans)	Karachay-Cherkessia and E. Adygea Gorges	6,5k - 8,5k	6,0k - 8,0k	38,0k - 47,0k
Karachay (Upper Kuban) and Five Balkar Societies (Baksan, Chegem, Khulam, Bezengi, Malkar)	High-Mountain Karachay-Cherkessia and Kabardino-Balkaria	4,0k - 5,2k	4,0k - 5,5k	25,0k - 32,0k
Adopted Regional Benchmark (Circassia and Central Ciscaucasia, 122,9k km2)	All 5 Sub-Regions (122,9k km2)	97,5k - 118,7k	94,0k - 125,0k	600,0k (530,0k - 680,0k)

Table 2. Population and household estimates for Circassia and Central Ciscaucasia c. 1700AD across principalities, tribal unions, and mountain societies.

The Eighteenth and Nineteenth Centuries (1700 - 1900AD)

Between 1700 and 1900AD, Northwestern and Central Ciscaucasia underwent the most dramatic demographic and ethnic transformation in its history [21][22][23][25][26].

During the first three quarters of the 18th century, indigenous Circassian, Kabardian, Abaza, Karachay-Balkar, and Ossetian populations expanded steadily from 600,0k in 1700AD to 670,0k (590,0k-750,0k) in 1750AD [17][21]. Following the Russo-Turkish War of 1768-1774 (Treaty of Küçük Kaynarca) and the annexation of the Crimean Khanate (1783), the Russian Empire constructed the Azov-Mozdok Fortified Line (1777-1780, including Stavropol, Georgievsk, Konstantinogorsk/Pyatigorsk, and Vladikavkaz in 1784), crushed the Kuban Nogai Horde under Suvorov in 1783, and in 1792-1793 resettled ~25,0k former Zaporozhian Cossacks (Black Sea Cossack Host / *Chernomorskoye kazach'ye voysko*) onto the right-bank Kuban plain between the Taman Peninsula and Ust-Labinsk (founding Yekaterinodar [Krasnodar] in 1793), followed by the Old Line Cossack regiments along the middle and upper Kuban (1794-1804) [21][25]. Total population across the five sub-regions reached 740,0k (650,0k-830,0k) in 1800AD.

During the early 19th century, Greater and Lesser Kabarda suffered a severe demographic collapse caused by the 1804-1812 plague epidemics, Russian military campaigns (1804, 1810, 1822, when General Yermolov

founded Nalchik), and the migration of *"fugitive Kabardians"* (*beglyye kabardintsy*) across the Kuban to join the Western Adyghe: Kabardian population fell from >150,0k-200,0k in the 1780s to ~35,0k-40,0k in the 1830s [21][26][67]. In Western Circassia, the construction of the Black Sea Coastline Forts (1837-1839), the Laba and Belaya fortified lines (with the founding of Maykop in 1857), and the final Russian offensive of 1859-1864 (ending at Kbaada / Krasnaya Polyana on 21 May 1864) culminated in the mass expulsion (*muhajirism*) of the Western Circassian and Abaza populations to the Ottoman Empire [22][23][66]. Official Russian embarkation logs compiled by A. P. Berger (1882) recorded 493 194 mountaineers deported through Black Sea ports (Anapa, Novorossiysk, Tuapse, Sochi, Adler) between 1858 and 1865 - including virtually the entire Ubykh, Natukhai, and coastal Shapsug populations, the majority of the Abadzekh, Temirgoy, Bjedukh, Hatukay, Besleney, and Shkaraua/Tapanta Abaza, and Kuban Nogais - while T. Kh. Kumykov (1994) and S. Kh. Khotko estimate total Circassian and Abaza demographic loss and emigration in 1858-1865 at 450,0k-600,0k+ [22][23][66]. Only ~50,0k-65,0k Western Circassians (settled in lowland villages of the Ekaterinodar and Maykop *otdels*) and ~9,0k-12,0k Abaza remained on the northwestern slopes by 1865 [21][26]. Because Slavic and Cossack military colonisation of the right-bank Kuban plain and Pyatigorye was already well underway by mid-century, total population across the five sub-regions stood at 920,0k (820,0k-1 020,0k) in 1850AD [21][25].

Following the 1860 formation of Kuban Oblast (uniting the Black Sea and Caucasus Line Cossack hosts into the Kuban Cossack Host), the 1861 Emancipation of the Serfs, the 1862 law on the settlement of the Western Caucasus foothills, and the construction of the Rostov-Vladikavkaz Railway (1875) and Tikhoretsk-Novorossiysk line (1888), over one million Russian and Ukrainian peasants (*inogorodniye*) and Cossacks poured into the fertile Kuban plains and foothill valleys [21][25]. In the First General Census of the Russian Empire (28 January 1897) [24][44], Kuban Oblast (94,3k km^2, encompassing modern Krasnodar Krai, Adygea, and Karachay-Cherkessia / Batalpashinsk Otdel) recorded 1 918 881 inhabitants (908,8k Ukrainians/Little Russians [47,4%], 816,7k Great Russians [42,6%], 38,5k Western Circassians & Adyghe, 26,9k Karachays, 20,1k Germans, 14,3k Greeks, 13,9k Armenians, and 12,4k Abaza and Nogais), with Yekaterinodar (Krasnodar) reaching 65 606 residents, Maykop 34 327, and Yeysk 35 414 [24][25]. Black Sea Governorate (*Chernomorskaya guberniya*, from Anapa/Novorossiysk to Sochi) recorded 57 478 inhabitants, including 16 897 in the port of Novorossiysk [24].

In Central Ciscaucasia (western Terek Oblast), the Nalchik Okrug (Kabarda and Balkaria) recorded 102 908 inhabitants (84,1k Kabardians and 23,2k Balkars/Mountain Tatars across the oblast), the Pyatigorsk (KMV) Otdel recorded ~125,0k inhabitants (centred on Pyatigorsk [18 440] and Kislovodsk), and North Ossetia (the Vladikavkaz Okrug plus Ossetian villages of the Mozdok/Sunzha border) recorded ~215,0k inhabitants (including 43 740 in Vladikavkaz city and 96,6k ethnic Ossetians in Terek Oblast) [21][24][44]. Summing all five sub-regions within their modern boundaries yields a total 1900AD population of 2 420,0k (2,42M; range 2,30M - 2,55M, or 19,69 persons/km^2): 1 650,0k in Krasnodar Krai, 215,0k in Adygea (Maykop lowland & foothill sector), 165,0k in Karachay-Cherkessia (Batalpashinsk sector), 235,0k in Kabardino-Balkaria & Pyatigorye/KMV, and 155,0k in North Ossetia-Alania (excluding the Ingush Nazran sector counted in the Chechnya-Ingushetia review) [21][24].

Limitations

Three main methodological constraints affect population estimates for Circassia and Central Ciscaucasia. First, unlike the permanent stone *auls* of the mountain gorges, the Azov-Kuban and Kuma steppes hosted mobile pastoral groups (Scythians, Siraces, Kipchaks, Lesser Nogais) whose winter camps (*kochev'ya*) along the Kuban and Kuma shifted seasonally across the Don-Manych watershed [11][20]. Second, because relative Black Sea and Azov sea levels rose by ~3,5-4,0 m since the 1st millennium BC (Phanagorian Transgression), roughly one-third of ancient Phanagoria, Patraeus, and Korokondame now

lies beneath Taman Bay, requiring bathymetric area adjustments when estimating Classical Bosporan urban populations [12][57]. Third, while Russian port commissions registered 493,2k *muhajirs* embarking at designated Black Sea ports [23], unrecorded departures on Ottoman feluccas along the Abkhaz-Ubykh-Shapsug coast and typhus mortality in coastal camps mean that pre-1860 Western Circassian population totals carry an uncertainty range of ~15% [22][66].

Conclusion

Spanning 122,9k km^2 from the Kerch Strait to the Darial Gorge, Historical Circassia and Central Ciscaucasia supported the largest population in the North Caucasus throughout the last twelve millennia (2,0k in 10000BC -> 70,0k under the Maykop Culture in 3000BC -> 225,0k during the Late Bronze and Koban plateau and terrace expansion in 1000BC -> 340,0k in the Classical Bosporan-Maeotian era at 1AD -> 470,0k at the Alanic-Zichian medieval peak in 1200AD -> 600,0k by 1700AD -> 740,0k by 1800AD). In the 19th century, the expulsion of the majority of the indigenous Western Circassian and Abaza population in 1860-1864 and the subsequent influx of over 1,7 million Kuban Cossacks and Slavic agrarian settlers transformed the demographic profile of the region, raising its population to 2 420,0k (2,42M) by 1900AD. Combining all three North Caucasian review regions (Dagestan: 690,0k, Chechnya-Ingushetia: 350,0k, and Circassia and Central Ciscaucasia: 2 420,0k) yields a total North Caucasus population of 1 188,0k (1,19M) at 1700AD and 3 460,0k (3,46M) at 1900AD across 194,0k km^2.

Appendix

Population Estimates

Benchmark	Krasnodar (75,5k km2)	Adygea (7,8k km2)	Karachay-Cherkessia (14,3k km2)	Kabardino-Balkaria and KMV (17,3k km2)	North Ossetia (8,0k km2)	Total Midpoint	Uncertainty Range [Low - High]	Density (p/ km2)
10000BC	0,90k	0,30k	0,25k	0,35k	0,20k	2,0k	1,2k - 3,0k	0,02
8000BC	1,60k	0,50k	0,45k	0,60k	0,35k	3,5k	2,2k - 5,0k	0,03
6000BC	3,50k	1,10k	0,95k	1,25k	0,70k	7,5k	5,0k - 10,5k	0,06
5000BC	6,0k	2,0k	1,6k	2,2k	1,2k	13,0k	9,0k - 18,0k	0,11
4000BC	14,0k	4,8k	3,5k	5,0k	2,7k	30,0k	22,0k - 38,0k	0,24
3000BC	34,0k	11,0k	8,0k	11,5k	5,5k	70,0k	55,0k - 85,0k	0,57
2000BC	46,0k	15,0k	12,0k	18,0k	9,0k	100,0k	80,0k - 120,0k	0,81
1500BC	64,0k	19,0k	24,0k	35,0k	18,0k	160,0k	135,0k - 190,0k	1,30
1000BC	92,0k	24,0k	32,0k	48,0k	29,0k	225,0k	190,0k - 260,0k	1,83
500BC	155,0k	32,0k	35,0k	55,0k	33,0k	310,0k	260,0k - 360,0k	2,52
1AD	175,0k	35,0k	38,0k	58,0k	34,0k	340,0k	290,0k - 390,0k	2,77
400AD	110,0k	22,0k	38,0k	56,0k	34,0k	260,0k	220,0k - 300,0k	2,12
600AD	130,0k	24,0k	48,0k	72,0k	41,0k	315,0k	270,0k - 360,0k	2,56

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Benchmark	Krasnodar (75,5k km2)	Adygea (7,8k km2)	Karachay-Cherkessia (14,3k km2)	Kabardino-Balkaria and KMV (17,3k km2)	North Ossetia (8,0k km2)	Total Midpoint	Uncertainty Range [Low - High]	Density (p/ km2)
800AD	148,0k	26,0k	55,0k	80,0k	46,0k	355,0k	305,0k - 405,0k	2,89
1000AD	178,0k	27,0k	68,0k	98,0k	59,0k	430,0k	375,0k - 485,0k	3,50
1200AD	195,0k	28,0k	72,0k	108,0k	67,0k	470,0k	410,0k - 530,0k	3,82
1300AD	165,0k	25,0k	56,0k	82,0k	52,0k	380,0k	330,0k - 430,0k	3,09
1400AD	150,0k	24,0k	46,0k	66,0k	44,0k	330,0k	285,0k - 375,0k	2,69
1500AD	190,0k	32,0k	54,0k	92,0k	47,0k	415,0k	365,0k - 465,0k	3,38
1600AD	232,0k	40,0k	63,0k	122,0k	48,0k	505,0k	445,0k - 565,0k	4,11
1700AD	275,0k	48,0k	72,0k	156,0k	49,0k	600,0k	530,0k - 680,0k	4,88
1750AD	310,0k	54,0k	78,0k	172,0k	56,0k	670,0k	590,0k - 750,0k	5,45
1800AD	365,0k	62,0k	85,0k	160,0k	68,0k	740,0k	650,0k - 830,0k	6,02
1850AD	520,0k	75,0k	95,0k	140,0k	90,0k	920,0k	820,0k - 1 020,0k	7,49
1900AD	1 650,0k	215,0k	165,0k	235,0k	155,0k	2 420,0k	2 300,0k - 2 550,0k	19,69

Table 3. Estimated population of Circassia and Central Ciscaucasia across its five sub-regional units (10000BC - 1900AD; total area 122,9k km2).

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